

GUITARHUB

FIELD GUIDE
No. 07

HOW LONG IS ENOUGH?

20 min? 2 hours?

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How long should you practice guitar *each day*?

Duration is the wrong variable. Here is the right one, how to tell when a session has stopped working, and what to do with 10, 25 or 60 minutes.

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There is no correct number of minutes. Duration is the wrong variable; attention is the right one. A focused twenty minutes changes your playing more than an unfocused two hours, because practice only moves what you are paying attention to. Practice as long as you can stay specific about what you are fixing, then stop.

If you want a number to start from, take twenty to forty minutes on most days over ninety minutes twice a week. Not because short sessions are special. Because a repair has to survive a night's sleep before you know it held, and the only way to run that test often is to practice often.

This page is about one session: how long it stays useful, and what belongs in ten, twenty-five or sixty minutes. It is the page that sizes a session and fills it. How those sessions are arranged across a week, which one you defend and what you cut when the week goes wrong, is the practice schedule's question rather than this one.

The limit is concentration, not fingers

Ask a player why they stopped and the answer is usually physical: tired hand, sore fingertips. Sore fingertips are real in the first few weeks and stop being the limit after that. What runs out first, for nearly everyone past that stage, is the ability to hold one specific target in mind and evaluate each attempt against it.

That evaluation is the expensive part of a session and the part that does the work. A repetition you did not evaluate still taught you something, just not the thing you chose. An hour of unevaluated repetition teaches you whatever your hands happened to do.

So the useful question is not how many minutes you can sit with the instrument. It is how many minutes you can stay specific. *The third finger lands late on the C, listen for it, fix it* is practice. *Run the song again* is a fine way to spend an evening and a poor way to fix a bar.

How to tell a session has stopped producing change

Sessions rarely end. They decay, and the decay is hard to notice from inside because it feels exactly like continuing. Any one of these tells can be a bad minute; two at once means the useful part of the session is behind you.

- **You cannot say what you are fixing.** Answer out loud. If it takes more than a second, or comes out as the name of a song rather than a location inside it, you are no longer aiming at anything.
- **Repetitions stop getting a verdict.** Early on you know instantly whether a pass was clean. Later the pass ends and you have no opinion. That is the evaluation shutting down, and it shuts down well before the hands do.
- **A mistake you had fixed comes back.** Not a new one — the old one, returning. You have dropped below the attention the fix requires, and every repetition from here argues with it.
- **You drift toward what already works.** The bar you came to repair gets shorter run-ups and the intro gets longer ones. Nobody decides to do this.
- **You raise the tempo out of boredom.** The honest reason to move up a rung is that the current one is clean and cold. Being tired of it is a different reason wearing the same clothes.
- **You start negotiating.** *One more good one and I will stop*, said twice, is a coin flip you keep re-flipping.

When two of those show up, stop. Stopping is the last measurement you take: a session that ends while you can still tell a clean pass from a dirty one ends with a result, and one that runs past that point ends with a fog.

Why long sessions can move you backwards

A practice session does not record your intentions. It records what your hands actually did, and it weights the late repetitions as heavily as the early ones. In the last stretch of a long session, what your hands do is the sloppy version. You are not failing to make progress there; you are making progress on the wrong take. That is why a two-hour night can leave a passage worse than it was at the forty-minute mark.

There is a second cost, harder to see. A long session produces a strong memory of effort, and that memory buys patience with an approach that is not working. Three weeks of twenty-five-minute sessions are easy to abandon when the recording says they did nothing. Three weeks of two-hour nights are not.

The check takes ninety seconds and is worth running on any session past about forty minutes. Before you pack up, play the thing you were repairing once, cold. If it is worse than it was mid-session, the last stretch cost you something, and tomorrow should be shorter.

Three session shapes

Time is the one budget you know in advance, so it is the sensible thing to plan against. All three shapes assume you already know your repair target. If you do not, the [GuitarHub method](#) covers how the target gets chosen and how you know when it is finished.

Ten, twenty-five and sixty are the common sizes, not the only ones. For a number that is none of those, the [practice session builder](#) splits whatever minutes you have into blocks that total exactly that length, weighted toward the one thing you named as broken. On a short evening it drops the blocks whose share came out too small to be worth starting, rather than shrinking all of them into setup time, and it tells you which ones went and why.

Ten minutes: one repair, recorded

Do not run a miniature version of your full routine. Five blocks at two minutes each is a checklist you ticked.

- **2 minutes.** The exact motion the target needs. Not general warm-up — that motion.
- **6 minutes.** The repair unit alone, at a tempo where you are correct on purpose rather than correct by luck.
- **2 minutes.** One cold pass of the passage in context, recorded, no second attempt.

The recording is what makes ten minutes count. Without it a short day leaves no trace, and a week of short days reads back as a plateau rather than a short week.

Twenty-five minutes: repair, then pressure

- **3 minutes.** The motion.
- **12 minutes.** The repair unit, tempo work folded into it. One target, not three. If you are climbing speeds, the tempo ladder builder decides which rung this session owns, so you are not deciding it while tired.
- **7 minutes.** The repaired part back inside the music, at a tempo where the whole passage survives rather than the fragment.
- **3 minutes.** One cold pass, recorded.

Twenty-five is the shape most weekday sessions should take: long enough to repair something and test the repair in one sitting, short enough that your evaluation still works at the test.

Sixty minutes: two sessions, not one

An hour is not a longer version of twenty-five minutes. Treat it as two sessions with a real break between them: put the guitar down, leave the room, five to ten minutes.

- **First half.** Repair, exactly as above, on one target.
- **The break.** Load-bearing, not optional. Without it the second half is the decayed tail of the first.
- **Second half.** A different job: repertoire, the whole piece, new material, or a second target that uses a different skill.

Changing jobs is the point of the break: the first target has had all the attention it can use today, and another twenty minutes on it is repetition without evaluation. If both halves have to be repair, make the second structurally different — a timing problem after a fretting-hand problem.

When a long session is the right call

None of this makes long sessions bad. It makes them bad at one job.

Repair — slow, evaluated, one passage at a time — degrades with duration. Plenty of guitar work does not.

- **Playing.** Ninety minutes of songs you already know is not practice and does not need to be. It is why most people picked up the instrument.
- **Learning new material.** Reading through a piece, working out an arrangement, finding fingerings. Exploratory work tolerates length far better than repair.
- **Stamina.** If the goal involves a forty-minute set, at some point you have to play for forty minutes without stopping.
- **Playing with other people.** A rehearsal runs as long as it runs, and what it builds — listening, holding your part, recovering mid-song — is not available alone in a room.

The mistake is counting those hours as practice and then wondering why the stuck bar is still stuck. Keep them in a separate column: a week with four hours of playing and eighty minutes of repair is a good week, and the eighty minutes is what moves the bar.

Days with almost no time

Some days you have four minutes between two obligations. Four minutes beats zero, but only if all four go to one thing.

- **3 minutes.** The single hardest join in what you are working on, slowly, correctly. Nothing else gets touched.

- **1 minute.** One cold pass of it, no retries, so the day produces a verdict instead of a feeling.

Skip the warm-up, skip repertoire, skip the ladder: each needs more repetitions than four minutes contains.

On a day with genuinely no minutes, the useful move is not a guilty two minutes with the guitar on your lap. It is thirty seconds with a note: write tomorrow's target in a sentence containing a location. Choosing the target is the one part of practice that is easier away from the instrument.

Making the number stick

Two counts matter more than session length: how many days a week you pick up the instrument, and how many end with a recorded verdict. Session length is what you adjust to protect those two. A forty-minute session that costs you the next two days was not really forty minutes.

For the weekly structure this sits inside — which blocks get cut first when the clock shrinks — see the [intermediate practice routine](#). For what to do inside the repair block once you are in it, [how to practice guitar effectively](#) is the companion piece to this one.

Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) takes the same problem from the scheduling side, and it has a companion piece on [practicing guitar with an AI coach](#).

Common questions

Is 30 minutes a day enough to get good at guitar?

Thirty attentive minutes a day is enough to keep moving, and for most players it is more than they currently get. It does not set the ceiling; the goal does that. Thirty minutes aimed at one passage will fix that passage, and the same thirty spread across five ambitions will fix none of them.

Should I practice every day, or take rest days?

Most days is the better default. Past the first few weeks, the limit on a session is attention rather than tissue recovery, so a day off is a scheduling decision. In the first weeks, fingertips are still toughening: keep sessions short, spread them across the day, and stop when a fingertip is sore. Pain at any stage is a reason to stop: hand, wrist or forearm pain gets looked at, not practiced through.

Does two hours a day improve you twice as fast as one?

No, because the attentive part of two hours is not twice the attentive part of one. Past the point where you can tell a clean repetition from a dirty one, the extra time rehearses the mistake instead of removing it. If you have two hours, split them and give the halves different jobs.

How long until I hear progress?

That depends on the goal, and no honest answer arrives in weeks. What you can do is make the answer checkable: record one passage today, work on it for four weeks, record it the same way again, and listen to both. That comparison settles it where a general number cannot.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 07. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/how-long-to-practice-guitar-each-day.

AI Instructions